

A PRACTICAL GUIDE

I want my Zeroberto

How to build your own AI agent with OpenClaw, step by step.

A computer
that stays on

An AI model
subscription or API key

Telegram
to talk to him

An afternoon
to set it up

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Practical AI Fireside Chat · Duke MBA Tech Club · Nov 10, 2026

BEFORE YOU START

What you are building

Zeroberto is BAP's AI agent. He has **his own computer**, access to the systems we grant him and a **working memory**. He is not a chatbot you visit: he works on his own schedule and reports back.

THREE THINGS WAKE HIM UP

A heartbeat
every 30 minutes he checks if there is something to do

Scheduled jobs
routines at exact times, like a daily cash check at 7 AM

A message
on Telegram or by email

HE ANSWERS

On Telegram
quick questions and alerts

By email
reports that land in the inbox of the person who owns the decision

The engine is **OpenClaw**, an open-source agent that runs on your own machine. It works as a gateway: messages and schedules come in, a language model does the reasoning, and tools reach your email, files and systems.

THE MAP

1. **Get him a computer**
   Mac mini or VPS
2. **Install OpenClaw**
   one line
3. **Connect the brain**
   the wizard
4. **Give him Telegram**
   and an inbox
5. **Give him a job**
   personality, rules, skills
6. **Wake him up**
   heartbeat and schedule
7. **Lock it down**
   least access
8. **Ship one routine**
   and let people correct him

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STEP 1

Get him a computer

An agent needs a machine that is always on. Not someone's laptop: laptops sleep, travel and get closed at the end of the day.

	MAC MINI	VPS (A RENTED SERVER IN THE CLOUD)
Where it lives	At the office or at home	In a data center
Cost	One-time hardware purchase	Small monthly fee
Good for	Teams that want the machine in their hands; the only option if you want iMessage	Telegram, WhatsApp, Slack or Discord as main channels; no hardware to manage
Watch out	Needs stable power and internet	Needs someone who knows basic server security

If you pick a Mac mini

- Create a **separate macOS user** just for the agent.
- System Settings: **prevent automatic sleep** and turn on **start up after a power failure**.
- Use a wired connection and a small UPS if you can.
- It runs fine without a monitor once set up.

If you pick a VPS

- Ubuntu is the common choice. A small server is enough: the heavy thinking happens in the AI model, not on your machine.
- Log in with an **SSH key**, never a password.
- Turn on the firewall and **do not expose the gateway port** to the internet.
- For remote access to the dashboard, use a private network such as Tailscale.

> **Tip.** BAP's Zeroberto runs on his own dedicated computer. Start small: you can always move him later, because his configuration lives in one folder.

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STEP 2

Install OpenClaw

One line in the terminal. OpenClaw is open source and free; you pay only for the AI model.

Requirement: **Node.js 24 or newer** (Node 26 is recommended). Check with `node --version`. If it is missing or old, the installer tells you.

```
# macOS or Linux (Mac mini or VPS)
$ curl -fsSL https://openclaw.ai/install.sh | bash
```

```
# Windows (PowerShell)
$ iwr -useb https://openclaw.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

```
# Just want to try it first, without installing?
$ npx openclaw@latest
```

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STEP 3

Connect the brain

A wizard links a language model and starts the gateway.

```
$ openclaw onboard
```

- **Quick start** detects an existing Claude Code or Codex login, or an API key, and tests it with a real answer.
- When it asks *"Keep OpenClaw running in the background?"*, answer **Yes**. That installs the gateway as a service, so it survives restarts.
- Changed your mind later? `openclaw configure` reopens the settings.

Check that the gateway is alive and open the control panel:

```
$ openclaw gateway status
# should show the gateway listening on port 18789
$ openclaw dashboard
```

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STEP 4

Give him Telegram, and an inbox

Telegram is the fastest channel to set up: you only need a bot token.

1. In Telegram, open a chat with **@BotFather** (check the handle is exactly that) and send `/newbot`. Choose a name and a username. Save the **token** it gives you.
2. Give the token to OpenClaw and check the channel:

```
$ openclaw channels add --channel telegram --token <YOUR-BOT-TOKEN>
$ openclaw channels status --probe
```

3. Send any message to your bot. That creates a **pairing request**. Approve it within one hour:

```
$ openclaw pairing list telegram
$ openclaw pairing approve telegram <CODE>
```

> **Tip.** Pairing is your first lock: strangers who find the bot get a pairing code, not an answer. Keep it on.

His own email

Give him **his own email account**, like a new colleague, never your personal inbox. Zeroberto is **jose.roberto@bap.com.br**. Reports go out from there, and the team answers him there. That is how people correct him without learning a new tool.

A name and a face

It sounds like a detail. It is not. People talk to a colleague; they do not talk to "the system". A name, a face and a badge made Zeroberto someone the team writes to, thanks and corrects.

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STEP 5

Give him a job

An agent is only as good as what you write down for him. OpenClaw reads a few plain-text files on every run.

FILE	WHAT GOES IN IT
`SOUL.md`	Personality and tone: who he is and how he talks.
`AGENTS.md`	House rules: what he does, what he never does, who to ask.
`MEMORY.md`	What he has learned: decisions, exceptions, corrections from the team.
`HEARTBEAT.md`	The short checklist he runs every time he wakes up (step 6).
`skills/`	One folder per routine, with written step-by-step instructions.

SOUL.md (example)

```
You are Zeroberto, the AI colleague of the
finance team at a property-management
company.
Be brief, polite and concrete. Write in the
language of the person who wrote to you.
When you are not sure, say so and ask.
```

AGENTS.md (example)

```
- You prepare and flag. People decide.
- Never pay, delete or send anything to a
  client without a human approval.
- Every report goes to the owner by email.
- When the team corrects you, write the new
  rule in MEMORY.md and confirm by email.
```

Tip. Start with **one skill**. Ours began with reading the ERP every morning and warning each account manager which balances could run out. One routine that someone wants beats ten that nobody reads.

STEP 6

6 Wake him up

Two ways to make him proactive instead of waiting to be asked.

Heartbeat

He wakes up at a fixed interval (ours is every 30 minutes), reads `HEARTBEAT.md` and checks if there is something to do. Good for many small checks batched together.

Scheduled jobs

A routine at an exact time: a cash-risk check at 7 AM, a closing report at 6 PM. In OpenClaw these are **Automations**, and you can see and edit them in the dashboard.

`HEARTBEAT.md (example)`

```
Every time you wake up:
1. Any unread email from the team? Answer or ask.
2. Any scheduled job that failed? Tell the owner.
3. Anything urgent in today's list? Flag it on Telegram.
If there is nothing to do, do nothing.
```

Tip. Keep `HEARTBEAT.md` short. It is read on every wake-up, and every line costs tokens. Batch small checks in the heartbeat; use scheduled jobs only when the exact time matters.

A day in Zeroberto's life, as inspiration

Night	Health check: systems, backups and every scheduled job
7 AM	Cash risk: balances, expected receipts and bills due
Morning	Payment audit: yesterday's payments, wrong categories, missing documents
All day	Service checks: friction in client emails, each building's own rules
End of day	Close the day: every payment due made? Risks and decisions for the team

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STEP 7

Lock it down

An agent with access to your systems is a new employee with keys. Treat it that way from day one.

- [ ] **His own accounts.** His own email, his own logins, his own operating-system user. Never share yours.
- [ ] **Only the access you grant.** One system at a time, read-only first. Use the system's API or an authorized account; never paste passwords into a prompt.
- [ ] **Keep pairing and allowlists on.** Unknown senders get a pairing code, not an answer. In groups, make him answer only when mentioned.
- [ ] **Do not expose the gateway.** By default it listens only on the machine itself. Keep it that way unless you know exactly what you are doing.
- [ ] **Vet every skill you install.** Skills from the internet are code. Read them before you enable them.
- [ ] **Set token limits.** For the agent and for the team. At BAP one user burned five times the allowed budget building an FAQ nobody used.
- [ ] **Log every run.** Every job reports back. We built Mission Control, one page that shows every automation and every result.

```
$ openclaw security audit
# run it after setup, and again after every big change
```

When something does not work

```
$ openclaw doctor          # shows what is wrong
$ openclaw triage          # read-only health checks
$ openclaw gateway restart # after changing the configuration
```

Telegram bot not answering? Usually a wrong token, a pairing that was never approved, or a gateway that is not running.

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STEP 8

Ship one routine, and let people correct him

The setup takes an afternoon. Making him useful takes weeks of small corrections.

1 He sends a report → 2 Someone replies with a correction → 3 He writes the new rule down → 4 Next report is better

> ***"Perfect. Go ahead and implement the rule."***
>
> Enne, BAP team, approving a rule the team taught Zeroberto by email

WHAT WE LEARNED THE HARD WAY

Pick one pain.
Recurring and bounded. First ask: should this process even exist?

Daily summary, not instant alerts.
Our first version sent alerts and managers ignored them. A daily synthesis gets read.

Every routine needs an owner.
A person who reads the output, corrects him and decides.

Measure the before.
One owner, one output, one number. Without it, you cannot tell if it worked.

Measure the review time.
If people spend longer checking his work than doing it, stop. Humans cannot become report reviewers.

Security before going online.
Our first application that went online was hacked by a betting site. Review before you publish.

Start with a workflow someone wants to use, not an architecture someone wants to admire.

KEEP IN TOUCH

Questions? Write to us.

Write to Zeroberto
jose.roberto@bap.com.br
Yes, he answers.

Rafael Thomé on LinkedIn
linkedin.com/in/rafaelth

SOURCES

- OpenClaw, Getting started: docs.openclaw.ai/start/getting-started
- OpenClaw, Telegram setup: docs.openclaw.ai/channels/telegram/setup
- OpenClaw, Security: docs.openclaw.ai/gateway/security
- OpenClaw, Automations: docs.openclaw.ai/automation
- Hostinger, How to set up OpenClaw on a Mac mini (2026)
- Bitdoze, OpenClaw setup guide: VPS or Mac mini (2026)

Commands checked against the official documentation in November 2026. OpenClaw changes often: if a command fails, check the docs first. This guide shares BAP's experience; it is not official OpenClaw documentation.